withdrawal of the PLO from Lebanon under international supervision, and the subsequent withdrawal of Syrian and Israeli armies. At the request of Lebanese leaders, I agreed that the United States would send a contingent of marines to Beirut for three or four weeks as part of a multinational peacekeeping force that would help supervise the departure of PLO forces to Tunisia and other countries.

With the shooting stopped, George Shultz and I regarded this moment in the explosive history of the Middle East as a possible golden opportunity to make a fresh start toward achieving a long-term settlement of the region's problems. We decided to offer the framework for a new peace initiative.

As we saw it, any long-term solution must require, first of all, that the Arab world acknowledge Israel's right to exist, and must provide adequate guarantees of Israel's security and the integrity of its borders. It should also provide for completion of the Camp David agreement, granting full autonomy to Palestinians living in the territories taken by Israel in the Six Day War, with free elections and a five-year transition period leading to full self-government; and a freeze by Israel on the establishment of new settlements in the occupied territories during the transition period, when there would be a peaceful and orderly transfer of authority from Israel to the Palestinians.

After its years of war against the PLO, we knew Israel would oppose (as would some Arab countries fearful of a strong Palestinian state) the creation of an independent Palestinian nation next to it on the West Bank and in Gaza. At the same time, we believed that peace would never come to the Middle East as long as the occupied territories remained under the permanent political control of Israel. We believed that the Palestinians living in these areas had to be given freedom, the right of self-determination and self-government, and that the best way of accomplishing this